

The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

You can begin to teach this principle even at the youngest ages by acknowledging when a child puts out extra effort. That does not mean equal performance necessarily. Each child has differing abilities and what may be extra effort to one may be coasting to another. You need to be able to evaluate when a child is trying harder.

One of our sons tended to be a perfectionist, even as a small child. Picking up his clothes and toys and cleaning his room were natural for him. As a result, he was praised and rewarded. Any parent who wouldn't do so would have to be a little crazy. Another son tended to be messy and rarely, if ever, noticed his disorder. When he took the time and effort to pick up his things or clean his room, he was looking for praise (or money). The more often we did so, the more normal it became for him. From time to time we raised our standards for rewards. It probably took three years before his "norm" reached the other son's low average. But had we never rewarded him in the beginning, the process would never have started.

It is effort, not skill level, you must measure and commend.

(4) *Stick to your convictions.* Don't be swayed into lowering your standards simply because you have Christian friends who do. Sometimes the most conflicting value system you'll find is in a Christian school. When your children are in contact with other children from Christian homes and find their values aren't the same, they will challenge your rules.

Unfortunately, many Christian parents don't pay by any performance standards and buy their children virtually anything they want, anytime they want it. The sad thing is that they actually believe this demonstrates love. The tendency is to be swayed in doing the same thing for your children. Don't compound their error. Remember that God's Word says, "He who spares his rod hates his son, but he who loves him disciplines him diligently" (Proverbs 13:24).

Discipline is not for punishment. It is to set boundaries for your children. Within those boundaries they are secure.

One of the major difficulties children have today is that they